The article was published in a paper that does not have an edition in Bangalore. Downloading it the morning it appeared, I noticed that the boys weaned on cow's milk had come sniffing already. One mailer complained that 'the "Southern Hilltop" the journalist so callously refers to here is the much-revered Lord Balaji's temple. Where do these people get the nerve?? Will he say "People running to middle eastern desert" for Haj pilgrimage?? This is called "Proving one's secular credentials" by putting down the most revered Lord in India.' Another angrily asked: 'Would Mr. Guha have taken a swipe at a Muslim person, worthy or worthless in her own right, for praying five times a day or for doing Haz? Why this step-motherly treatment for visiting temples?'

Fortunately, these mailers had been put in their place by an Indian with a sense of proportion, who responded to their screeds as follows: 'There we go again, just drag religious sentiments into it, and finish off with a Hindu-Muslim comparison to highlight a perceived bias. [Guha] was commenting on [Nita Ambani's] visits to pray "for, of all things, a cricket team" … The point being she was praying not for literacy, not for end of poverty, not for benefit of fellow man, country or world but her commercial interests in a cricket franchise.'

IV

The number and intensity of Hindutva hate mails in my Inbox has varied over the past two decades. They have increased and become more abusive at particular moments—after the Gujarat riots of 2002, for example, or after the terror attack in Mumbai of 2008. Before the General Elections of 1999, 2004 and 2009 I also got a flood of mails warning me that I would be put in my place once the party of the faithful would be elected or re-elected to power. The mails fly thick and fast in times of political controversy, but they by no means dry up in quieter periods in-between. For the hard-core fundamentalist, the hunt for heretics is a full-time business.